

HE IS RISEN

Resurrection Evidence Before The Gospels

A COMPANION GUIDE

For Personal Reflection or Small Group Study

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How to Use This Guide

Each chapter entry in this guide can be read alone, slowly, with a cup of coffee and a pen — or brought into a room with other people. This resource works through the historical evidence for the resurrection chapter by chapter, so treat it like building a case: each entry adds another piece.

If you're using this guide on your own, work through all five questions at your own pace, journaling your answers as you go. If you're leading a group, feel free to pick two or three rather than working through the whole list — the goal is a real conversation, not a completed worksheet.

Each entry includes the chapter's key Scripture passage, a short devotional idea, a pull-quote from the book, five reflection questions, and a closing prayer. Use whatever pace fits your life — one chapter a day, one a week, or one per group session.

CHAPTER ONE

All or Nothing

Read: 1 Corinthians 15:14

THE IDEA

Every Christian has made an all-in bet, whether they realize it or not. Paul said it plainly: if Christ has not been raised, our preaching is worthless and so is our faith. There's no back-up plan in Christianity, no fallback position if the resurrection turns out to be a legend or a lie.

Before we can ask what the resurrection means, we have to ask something more basic: did it actually happen? That question deserves an honest answer, not a borrowed one. The rest of this guide walks through the evidence the way a courtroom would, because a faith built on wishful thinking isn't faith worth having. A faith built on evidence is.

SIT WITH THIS

"There is nothing more important or more central to the Christian message than the resurrection of Jesus."

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. Have you ever actually examined the evidence for the resurrection, or have you simply inherited the belief without testing it?
2. Why do you think Paul was willing to say his whole faith would be "useless" if the resurrection didn't happen?
3. What's the difference between believing something because it's comforting and believing it because it's true?
4. Where are you currently placing more confidence in a feeling about your faith than in the reasons for it?
5. What holds you back from investigating the evidence for yourself?

PRAY

Jesus, I don't want a borrowed faith. Give me the courage to examine the evidence and the honesty to follow where it leads. Amen.

CHAPTER TWO

Early, Reliable Testimony

Read: 1 Corinthians 15:3–8 · Galatians 1:18, 2:1

THE IDEA

Good history runs on good witnesses, not vague impressions. Paul's letter to the Galatians gives us a timeline: he came to faith within a few years of the crucifixion, and he was writing to the Corinthians about the resurrection appearances less than twenty years after the event itself.

Paul doesn't just claim the resurrection happened; he names the eyewitnesses, many of whom were still alive and could be asked directly. Combine his testimony with three other first-century writers who each independently confirm the resurrection, and the picture becomes hard to dismiss.

SIT WITH THIS

“You can't lie about something when the people you mention are still alive to correct you.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. Does it change anything for you to know how close Paul's testimony is to the actual event, compared to other ancient history you accept without question?
2. Why does the timing of Paul's testimony matter so much to its credibility?
3. How does Paul naming living witnesses function differently than a vague, unverifiable claim?
4. Have you ever dismissed the resurrection as “just a legend” without checking the actual timeline of the evidence?
5. What's one piece of “early, reliable testimony” you could share with someone who doubts the resurrection?

PRAY

Lord, thank You for leaving real evidence, not just a story to take on blind faith. Strengthen my confidence in what actually happened. Amen.

CHAPTER THREE

Alternate Explanations

Read: 1 Corinthians 15:3–8

THE IDEA

Any good detective knows a solid case has to explain the “totality of the circumstances” — not just one piece of evidence while ignoring the rest. Over the centuries, several theories have tried to explain away the empty tomb and the appearances: Jesus merely swooned, the disciples hallucinated, the body was stolen, or the whole story was fabricated.

Each theory sounds plausible in isolation, but none of them can carry the full weight of the evidence alone. Stacking multiple theories together to explain away one event is a sign the simplest explanation — He actually rose — deserves a second look.

SIT WITH THIS

“The strength of a totality argument rests on the combined value of all the evidence in a case, rather than relying on only one piece.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. Which alternate theory have you found most convincing in the past, and does it hold up under this closer look?
2. Why does combining multiple theories together actually weaken an argument instead of strengthening it?
3. What do you make of the fact that none of the disciples recanted, even under torture?
4. How does the “dead men don’t walk” position differ from an actual evidence-based theory?
5. If someone raised one of these alternate theories with you, how would you respond now?

PRAY

Father, give me the courage to follow the evidence honestly, wherever it points, and the discernment to see through explanations that don’t hold up. Amen.

CHAPTER FOUR**The Final Verdict**

Read: 1 Corinthians 15:20–22

THE IDEA

Every juror eventually has to render a verdict. After weighing the early testimony and the failure of every alternate theory, the resurrection stands as the explanation that accounts for all the evidence without creating new problems.

Paul put the stakes plainly to the Corinthians: Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep. There is no comfortable middle ground here. Either the tomb stayed shut, or it didn't.

SIT WITH THIS

“Is He risen?”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. Based on the evidence you've walked through, what verdict are you actually rendering right now?
2. Why do you think Paul calls Jesus the “firstfruits” of the resurrection?
3. Is there room for a comfortable middle ground on the resurrection? Why or why not?
4. If the resurrection is true, what part of your life still hasn't caught up to that truth?
5. What's stopping you from rendering a final verdict of your own?

PRAY

Jesus, I don't want to stay undecided. Help me render an honest verdict and then live like it's true. Amen.

CHAPTER FIVE

What Now?

Read: 1 Corinthians 15:20–22

THE IDEA

Evidence without response is just information. Once you've weighed the evidence for the resurrection, you're responsible for what you do with your conclusion. If you're convinced, the next step isn't complicated — it starts with a simple prayer of trust, placing your faith in a Savior who actually conquered death.

From there, Christianity isn't meant to be lived alone. No Christian is an island. Faith placed in a risen Jesus is meant to grow inside a community that helps you learn what He taught and live it out.

SIT WITH THIS

“No Christian is an island. We need each other.”

QUESTIONS TO SIT WITH

1. Where are you right now — still investigating, convinced but not yet committed, or ready to place your trust in Jesus?
2. Why does the author insist that “no Christian is an island”?
3. If you prayed the prayer in this chapter honestly, what would change in how you live this week?
4. What would it look like to find a church community if you don't currently have one?
5. What's one next step you could take this week toward actually living this out?

PRAY

Jesus, I believe You rose from the dead to prove You are God. I place my faith and trust in You. Teach me Your ways, and lead me into a community that will help me follow You. Amen.